

AKANKSHA ARORA

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EDUCATION

University of California, Santa Barbara PhD Economics	June 2026
University of Texas at Austin MS Economics	May 2019
Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi MA Economics	Apr 2009
Lady Shri Ram College, University of Delhi BA (Honours) Economics	Apr 2007

WORKING PAPERS

[Job Market Paper] Educational Expansion and Assortative Matching: Evidence from the Marriage Market in India

Using staggered school construction across Indian districts, I estimate the effects of increased school access on women's educational attainment and marriage outcomes. An additional school per 1,000 school-age children, equivalent to about an 11 percent increase over the sample mean, raises women's years of schooling by nearly 2 percent and increases primary school completion by about 3 percent, with no significant effect on secondary education. Improved access to schooling also delays marriage, narrows the spousal age gap, and reduces child marriage: a comparable expansion raises the age at marriage by roughly 0.2 percent, decreases the spousal age gap by about 0.5 percent, and increases the probability of remaining unmarried by age 18 by approximately 0.5 percent. Beyond individual outcomes, school expansion reshaped marriage markets by strengthening educational sorting between spouses. Assortative matching increased among the least educated groups, while remaining comparatively stable or declining modestly at higher education levels, suggesting increased stratification at the lower end of the education distribution. Each additional school raises the assortative mating index by about 1.6 percent, and back-of-the-envelope calculations suggest that school expansion accounts for roughly 43 percent of the observed rise in assortative mating across marriage cohorts. However, I find little evidence that increased schooling improves women's intra-household outcomes: decision-making power remains unchanged, domestic violence exhibits strong intergenerational persistence, and there is no evidence of backlash driven by changes in relative spousal education. These findings indicate that large-scale investments in schooling improved women's human capital and delayed marriage while reshaping patterns of marital sorting, without substantially altering intra-household dynamics.

School Construction, Household Formation, and Intergenerational Human Capital in India

Using staggered school construction across Indian districts, I estimate the effects of increased school access on women's fertility behavior and the educational and health outcomes of the next generation. An additional school per 1,000 school-age children, equivalent to roughly an 11 percent increase relative to the sample mean exposure, delays age at first birth for women by approximately 0.03 years and reduces completed fertility by nearly 6 percent over the life cycle. Increased school access also generated significant intergenerational improvements in children's educational attainment, increasing years of schooling by 8.6

percent and reducing the probability of falling behind grade level by nearly 19 percent. School construction additionally improves child height-for-age and increases the likelihood of institutional delivery. Overall, the findings suggest that large-scale investments in schooling generated persistent intergenerational benefits extending beyond directly exposed cohorts. School construction increased parental educational attainment and altered the distribution of education across households, but I find limited evidence that educational expansion substantially strengthened complementarities between parents in the production of child human capital.

Workfare, Marriage and Women's Fertility: Evidence from India

I estimate the effect of an expansion in employment opportunities available to women in India on their marriage and fertility choices. While overall female labour force participation in India has stagnated at very low levels, women's participation in the workfare program, the National Rural Employment Guarantee Act, is fairly high. Using the staggered adoption of this workfare program across Indian districts for identification, I estimate whether the program had an effect on rates of marriage, fertility and sex ratio at birth. In my analysis, conditional on district covariates interacted with time in an age-adjusted model, the introduction of the workfare program led to 7.6 fewer marriages per 1000 women (3.6 fewer marriages based on the heterogeneity-robust estimator). Conceptions ending in live births per 1000 women fell by 19.1 in the 20-24 age group but rose by 15.5 in the 25-29 age group, indicating a shift towards later childbearing which may potentially reduce overall fertility in the long-run.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

University of California, Santa Barbara

Sep 2019 - Jun 2026

Teaching Assistant/Associate for following courses:

- Econ 1: Principles of Microeconomics (Fall 2019, Winter 2020, Spring 2020, Fall 2021, Winter 2022, Fall 2022, Fall 2023)
- Econ 114B: Economic Development (Fall 2020, Winter 2021, Summer 2022, Summer 2024)
- Econ 114A: Economic Development (Spring 2024, Fall 2024)
- Econ 100B: Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (Spring 2021)
- Econ 10A: Intermediate Microeconomic Theory (Summer 2021, Winter 2023)
- Econ 101: Intermediate Macroeconomic Theory (Spring 2022, Winter 2024, Winter 2025, Spring 2025)
- Econ 2: Principles of Macroeconomics (Spring 2023)
- Globl 130: Global Economy and Development (Fall 2025) – **Associate**
- Econ 140A: Introduction to Econometrics (Spring 2026)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

University of California, Santa Barbara

Jun 2023 - Sep 2023

Research Assistant for Kelsey Jack - Conducted data analysis for randomized control trial in Ghana

- Targeting Subsidies through Price Menus: Menu Design and Evidence from Clean Fuels: RCT in Ghana studying the cost-effectiveness of non-linear price subsidies for LPG cylinders.

University of Texas at Austin

Sep 2018 - May 2019

Research Assistant for Tom Vogl - Conducted data analysis using DHS & WFS data

- Malthus in Africa? Positive and Preventive Checks on Population in a Changing Climate: This study analyzes the impact of short-term weather shocks and long-term climate change on fertility and infant mortality in Africa utilizing data from Demographic and Health Surveys & World Fertility Surveys.

Princeton University

Mar 2016 - May 2017

Research Specialist for Jeremy Shapiro - Managed multiple randomized control trials in Kenya and conducted data analysis

- Benchmarking Aid Programs: A Preference-Based Approach: The study develops a replicable methodology to elicit the valuation of different types of in-kind aid programs relative to direct cash transfers from recipients.
- The Impact of Recipient Preferences on Aid Effectiveness: The study investigates the welfare impact of incorporating recipient preferences in the allocation of aid resources by randomly allocating subjects to receive either aid programs or their cash transfer equivalent.
- The Impact of Mental Health Support and Cash Transfers on Intimate Partner Violence: A randomized controlled trial to assess the differential and joint impact of the Problem Management Plus mental health support program and cash transfers on intimate partner violence and household welfare outcomes.
- The Impact of Digital Financial Services: BMGF-funded study to investigate the impact of expanding access to services on the M-Pesa rails among marginalized populations in Kenya using an encouragement design randomized controlled trial.

J-PAL South Asia

Nov 2013 - Jun 2015

Research Associate for James Berry & Priya Mukherjee - Managed randomized control trials on education in India, conducted data cleaning and analysis

- Pricing of Education Services in Urban India – Demand, Use and Impact: The study aims to characterize the market for private tutorial services by estimating the screening and sunk-cost effects of prices on take-up and utilization.
- The Effects of Social Identity on Aspirations and Learning Outcomes – A Field Experiment in Rural India: A behavioural field experiment that utilizes priming to examine the impact of caste and gender identity salience on aspirations and learning outcomes.

J-PAL South Asia

Sep 2011 - Feb 2012

Research Associate for Abhijit Banerjee, Esther Duflo, Clément Imbert & Rohini Pande - Managed fieldwork on a randomized control trial on voter information campaigns in India

- Entry, Exit and Candidate Selection – Evidence from India: The study examines the effect of a voter information campaign on likelihood of incumbents standing for re-election for village council positions and their electability.

Indian Statistical Institute, Delhi

Jan 2010 - Oct 2010

Research Assistant for E. Somanathan - Managed fieldwork and conducted data analysis

- Are Embankments a Good Flood-Control Strategy? A Case Study of the Kosi River: An impact assessment of the 2008 floods caused by the River Kosi embankment breach on labour and agricultural market outcomes.

Delhi School of Economics

Jul 2009 - Dec 2009

Research Assistant for Rohini Somanathan - Assisted with fieldwork and data cleaning

- School Meals and Classroom Effort – Evidence from India: Delhi Directorate of Education funded impact evaluation of the mid-day meal scheme on attendance & cognitive functioning of students.

OTHER WORK EXPERIENCE

Evidence Action - Deworm the World

Jun 2012 - Oct 2013

Data Coordinator

Developed monitoring and evaluation framework and conducted data analysis for school-based deworming program scale-up

American Express

Nov 2010 - Mar 2011

Business Analyst

Developed predictive models to estimate and profile consumer spending in various industry segments

ICICI Bank

May 2008 - Jul 2008

Analyst (Intern)

Developed propensity score models to enhance effectiveness of cross-selling of financial products

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Proficient	Stata, L ^A T _E X
Intermediate	R, SAS, SQL, QGIS

LANGUAGES

Fluent	English, Hindi, Punjabi
Intermediate	French